STUDENT WORKBOOK

SWIM & WATER SAFETY

Health & Physical Education · Year 7–8

Victorian Curriculum F–10 Version 2.0

STUDENT NAME	CLASS	TEACHER

VCHPEP125 · VCHPEP126 · VCHPEP129 · VCHPEP130 · VCHPEM146 · Safety (S) · LPA · FMS

Victoria has some of the most beautiful — and most dangerous — water environments in Australia. This workbook builds the knowledge, skills and confidence to keep yourself and others safe in and around water.

Complete all activities thoughtfully. Colour is used only where it helps you identify beach flags (Activity 2.1) and understand rip currents (Activity 2.2).

Welcome to your Swim & Water Safety Workbook.

Victoria has some of the most beautiful beaches, rivers, lakes and pools in Australia — and some of the most dangerous conditions. This workbook will help you build the knowledge, skills and confidence to keep yourself and others safe in and around water. Complete all activities thoughtfully and honestly.

1 Why Water Safety Matters in Victoria

Key Knowledge — Victorian Drowning Statistics 2023–24

- 54 fatal drownings in Victoria in 2023–24 — the highest in decades
- 1 in 5 victims were aged 15–24 years old
- Males are 4x more likely to drown than females
- **ALL 54 deaths occurred at unpatrolled locations**
- Inland waterways (rivers, dams) are especially dangerous
- Cold water shock can affect even strong swimmers
- Non-fatal drownings were 60% above the 10-year average
- ~40% of deaths were from CALD backgrounds — highest ever recorded

Source: Life Saving Victoria Drowning Report 2023-24 — lsv.com.au/research/victorian-drowning-reports/

Activity 1.1 — Personal Connection

Individual | ~5 min

Think about your own experiences near or in water. Circle your answer for each question.

Favourite water environment (circle one):	My swimming ability (circle one):
Patrolled Beach / Unpatrolled Beach / Public Pool / Private Pool / River / Dam / Lake / I avoid water	Non-swimmer / still learning / Can swim short distances / Comfortable swimmer / Strong / confident swimmer

Activity 1.2 — Data Analysis

Individual | ~10 min

Study the Victorian drowning statistics below. Complete the third column with your own interpretation of what each figure tells us.

Category	2023–24 Data	What does this tell us?
Total fatal drownings	**54 deaths**	*Write your interpretation here...*
Young people aged 15–24	**1 in 5 victims**	
Gender	**46 of 54 were male**	
Location	**ALL at unpatrolled sites**	

Question 1.2a **[2 marks]**

Using the data above, explain TWO reasons why teenagers and young people in Victoria face a higher risk of drowning.

1. ______________________________

Question 1.2b **[2 marks]**

All 54 Victorian drowning deaths in 2023–24 occurred at unpatrolled locations. What does this suggest about the importance of swimming at patrolled beaches and pools?

2 Beach Flags, Signals & Safe Swimming

Key Knowledge — Australian Beach Flag System

- **Red & Yellow flags** = patrolled swimming area — ALWAYS swim here
- **Single red flag** = dangerous conditions — extreme caution or no entry
- **Black & white quartered** = surfers/watercraft zone — not for swimmers
- **Yellow + black ball** = swimming only — no surfboards allowed
- **Orange windsock** = offshore winds — no inflatables
- **Purple flag** = dangerous marine life present
- Lifeguards are trained professionals — always follow their instructions
- BeachSafe app shows patrolled beaches near you: beachsafe.org.au

Source: Surf Life Saving Australia – sls.com.au | Life Saving Victoria – lsv.com.au

Activity 2.1 — Flag Identification ★ COLOUR

Individual | ~8 min

Below are six beach flag diagrams. Write the correct **name** and **meaning** of each flag in the spaces provided beneath each flag.

Flag 1: ______________________________

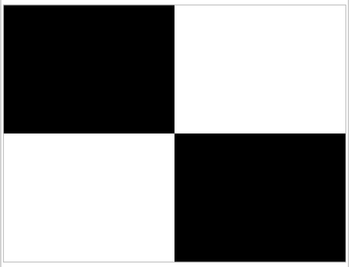
Meaning: ______________________

____

Flag 2: ______________________________

Meaning: ______________________

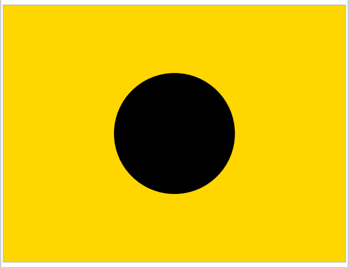
____



Flag 3: ______________________________

Meaning: ______________________

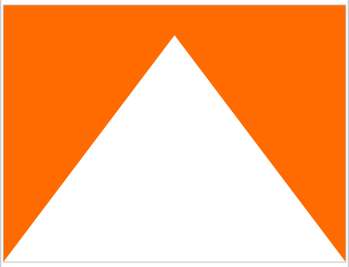
____



Flag 4: ______________________________

Meaning: ______________________

____



Flag 5: ______________________________

Meaning: ______________________

____

Flag 6: ______________________________

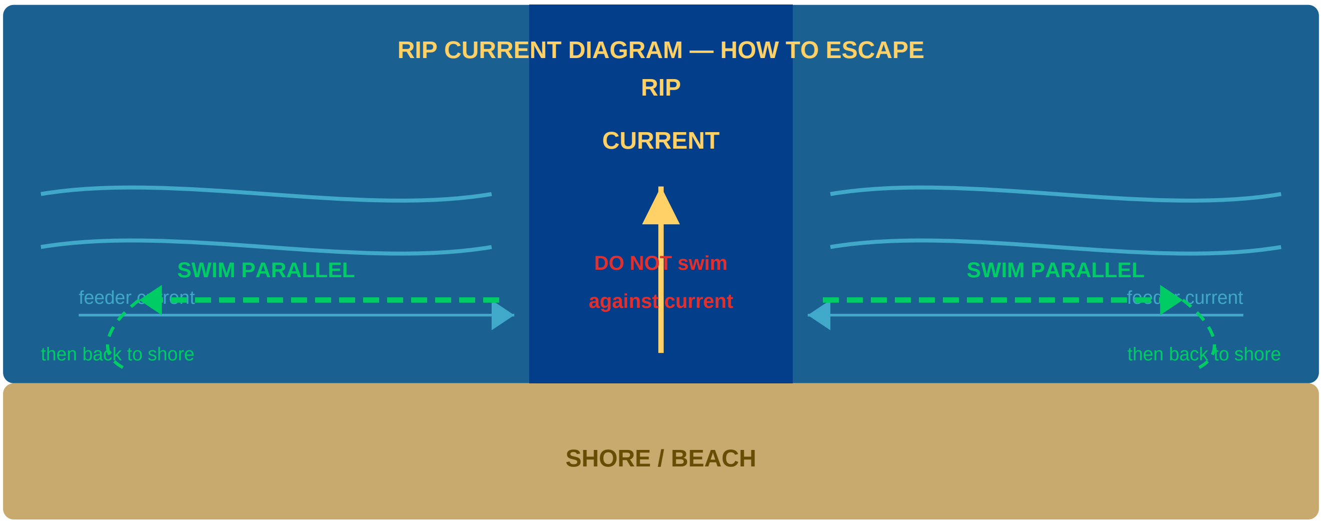
Meaning: ______________________

____

Activity 2.2 — Rip Currents: How to Escape ★ COLOUR

Individual | ~10 min

Rip currents are one of the leading causes of drowning at Australian beaches. They are fast-moving channels of water that flow from the shore out to sea. Study the diagram carefully, then answer the questions below.



1. Stay CALM
2. FLOAT
3. Swim PARALLEL
4. Angle to shore
5. SIGNAL for help

Question 2.2a [3 marks]

Using the diagram above, describe in your own words the THREE steps you would take if caught in a rip current.

Step 1: ______________________________

____

____

____

Question 2.2b [2 marks]

Why is it dangerous to try to swim directly against a rip current towards shore?

____

____

Scenario

Liam is a 14-year-old who went to the beach with friends on a hot summer day. They went to an unpatrolled beach. Liam swam out and felt himself being pulled away from shore. He began panicking and tried to sprint-swim directly back to the beach, but was getting more tired. His friends noticed and did not know what to do.

Question 2.2c **[4 marks]**

Identify TWO mistakes Liam and his friends made, and explain what they should have done differently.

Mistake 1: ____

3 Emergency Response — DRS ABCD

Key Knowledge — The DRS ABCD Action Plan

- **D**anger — check for hazards before approaching
- **R**esponse — check if the person responds to you
- **S**end — call 000 (triple zero) for emergency services
- **A**irway — tilt head back, lift chin, check for obstruction
- **B**reathing — look, listen, feel for up to 10 seconds
- **C**PR — 30 compressions, 2 breaths; repeat until help arrives
- **D**efibrillation — use AED if available; follow voice prompts
- **THROW, DON'T GO** — use reach or throw rescue first

Source: St John Ambulance Victoria — stjohnvic.com.au/first-aid-resources/

Critical Safety Rule — THROW, DON'T GO

Most bystanders who enter dangerous water to help end up drowning themselves. Always attempt a reach or throw rescue first. Throw a rope, towel, kickboard, esky lid, or any floating object. Only enter water to rescue if you are trained to do so.

Activity 3.1 — DRS ABCD Memory Activity

Individual | ~5 min

Write the word that each letter stands for, then describe what you would DO at each step if you found someone unconscious face-down at the edge of a swimming pool.

Step	Word	What I would do:
D	DANGER	*e.g. Look for any electricity, chemicals, or pool hazards...*
R		
S		
A		
B		
C		
D		

Activity 3.2 — Rescue Scenario Analysis

Pairs | ~12 min

Scenario — The River Rope Swing

Scene: It is a hot February day. You and your friends are at a popular (but unpatrolled) rope swing over a river. A 16-year-old you don't know swings out, lets go, and hits the water awkwardly. He sinks and doesn't come back up. His friends are watching from the bank. One of them jumps in to help and also starts struggling. You are standing on the bank. You have a towel, a rope attached to the swing, and your phone.

Question 3.2a [2 marks]

What is your FIRST action and why? (Consider the "throw, don't go" principle)

Question 3.2b [2 marks]

Why is it dangerous that the friend jumped in? What risk does this create?

Question 3.2c [3 marks]

If you pull the unconscious teenager to the bank and he is not breathing, list the DRS ABCD steps you would take in order.

1. ____________________ *2.* ____________________ *3.* ____________________

4 Making Safe Decisions Near Water

Key Knowledge — Factors That Increase Risk

- Peer pressure to swim in dangerous locations
- Overestimating your swimming ability
- Cold water shock (involuntary gasp reflex)
- Alcohol and drug use impairs judgment
- Swimming alone with no-one watching
- Jumping or diving without checking depth
- Ignoring warning signs and flags
- Inflatable toys in open water with offshore winds

LSV SwimSafe Rules — 5 Rules Before You Enter Water

- **Read Signs** — Always check warning signs, flags, and notices before entering any waterway
- **Enter Feet First** — Never dive or jump into unknown water
- **Stay In Depth** — Only swim where you can comfortably stand, unless you are a confident swimmer
- **Swim With a Friend** — Never swim alone — drowning is silent
- **Signal For Help** — Raise ONE arm if in trouble. Float and conserve energy until help arrives

Source: Life Saving Victoria SwimSafe Program — lsv.com.au

Activity 4.0 — Hazard Mapping

Pairs | ~10 min

For each Victorian water environment below, list at least THREE specific hazards. Rank each H (High), M (Medium) or L (Low) risk.

Environment	Hazards (list at least 3)	Risk (H/M/L)	How to stay safe
Patrolled Beach (e.g. Torquay, Mornington)	1. ____________ 2. ____________ 3. ____________		
River / Dam (e.g. Yarra, Lake Eildon)	1. ____________ 2. ____________ 3. ____________		
Pool (public, school, or backyard)	1. ____________ 2. ____________ 3. ____________		

Question 4.0a [2 marks]

Which environment is MOST dangerous overall, and why? Use Victorian drowning statistics to support your answer.

Activity 4.1 — Risk vs. Benefit Analysis

Individual | ~10 min

For each situation, identify the RISK(S) and a SAFER ALTERNATIVE.

Situation	Risk(s)	Safer Alternative
Swimming at an unpatrolled beach at night on a dare from friends		
Using an inflatable lilo in the ocean on a windy day		
Jumping into a river from rocks without knowing the depth		
Going for a swim alone in a dam on a hot day		

Question 4.1a **[3 marks]**

Describe a strategy to resist peer pressure to swim somewhere unsafe. Give a specific example of what you might say to your friends.

Strategy: ______________________________

5 Victorian Inland Waterways, Cold Water & Rescue

Activity 5.1 — Cold Water Shock Research Task

Individual / pair | ~15 min

Victorian rivers, dams and lakes can be dangerously cold even on a hot summer day. Cold water shock is a physiological response that can incapacitate even strong swimmers.

Cold Water Shock Facts:

When you suddenly enter cold water (below about 15 degrees C), your body triggers an involuntary gasp reflex, rapid breathing, increased heart rate and blood pressure, and muscle weakness. These responses can cause you to inhale water and drown within minutes, even in shallow water. Alpine lakes such as Lake Eildon are fed by snowmelt and can remain below 15 degrees C even in December and January.

Question 5.1a [2 marks]

Describe TWO physical effects cold water has on the body that can increase the risk of drowning.

1. ______________________________

Question 5.1b [2 marks]

What are TWO precautions you should take if you plan to swim or fish at an inland waterway in Victoria?

1. ______________________________

Question 5.1c — Research [2 marks]

Visit one of the sites below and find ONE fact about Victorian inland waterway safety you did not know before. Write the exact URL of the page you found it on.

Fact: ______________________________

vic.gov.au/water-safety | lsv.com.au | paddle.org.au | park.vic.gov.au

Activity 5.2 — Throw Rescue: Rank Your Equipment

Groups of 3-4 | ~8 min

Based on guidelines from the **Royal Life Saving Society Australia (RLSSA)**, the safest rescues keep YOU out of the water. Rank the items from BEST (1) to WORST (5) and explain WHY.

Item	Rank (1-5)	Why? (advantage or limitation)
Coiled rope / throw bag		
Life ring attached to the jetty		

Item	Rank (1-5)	Why? (advantage or limitation)
Jumping in and swimming to them		
Throwing a pool noodle or esky lid		
Holding out a towel or clothing from the bank		

Source: RLSSA rescue guidelines — royallifesaving.com.au

Activity 5.3 — Alcohol, Risk & Water

Individual | ~8 min

Alcohol is a significant factor in Victorian drowning deaths.

Question 5.3a [3 marks]

List THREE specific ways that alcohol affects the body that increase the risk of drowning.

1. ______________________________

Question 5.3b [2 marks]

A group of older teenagers are at a pool party. Some have been drinking. One decides to swim "to cool off." What are TWO specific risk factors that make this more dangerous than swimming sober?

1. ______________________________

Activity 5.4 — Diving, Shallow Water & Spinal Injury

Individual | ~12 min

Key Data — Australian Diving & Spinal Injury Statistics

- Unsafe diving accounts for approximately **10%** of all spinal cord injuries and **20%** of quadriplegia cases in Australia (AIHW).
- **95%** of aquatic spinal injury patients are male — and the highest incidence age group is children aged **10-14**.
- **Two-thirds** of patients suffer permanent disability — often quadriplegia (paralysis of all four limbs).
- The cervical spine (neck vertebrae) fractures on impact when a person dives into water shallower than expected. Spinal cord tissue cannot regenerate — the damage is permanent.
- A sandbank, tidal change, or seasonal depth variation can make a familiar location dangerous without any visible warning.

Sources: AIHW Diving Injury Report — aihw.gov.au | Royal Perth Hospital spinal injury review | Royal Life Saving Australia — royallifesaving.com.au

Three Recent Australian Case Studies:

Case study	Location & year	What happened	Key lesson
1	Terrigal Wharf, NSW — 2025	A teenage boy dived from a wharf into water he believed was deep. Serious spinal injuries. Helicopter evacuation to hospital.	Wharves and jetties can be over surprisingly shallow or tidal water. Structure height does not indicate water depth.
2	Torquay Front Beach, VIC — 2025	A teenage boy suffered a serious suspected spinal injury diving at a surf beach and was airlifted to hospital.	Surf beach sandbanks shift with every tide — depth at any point is constantly and unpredictably changing.
3	Bawley Beach Jetty, NSW — 2024	A young man was seriously injured diving from a jetty. A sandbank had recently formed beneath the jumping spot between visits.	Prior safe experience at a location creates false confidence. Always check depth on every single visit.

The Core Prevention Message:

"Feet First, First Time — Every Time."

Always enter unknown water feet-first before diving or jumping — and check depth on every visit, not just the first. Water depth changes due to tides, sandbanks, drought, flooding, and sediment build-up. A location that was safe last time may not be safe today.

Question 5.4a **[2 marks]**

The data shows that 95% of aquatic spinal injury patients are male and the highest incidence age group is 10-14 years. In your own words, explain why YOU might be in a higher-risk group for this type of injury, and what specific behaviour creates that risk.

Think about: peer pressure, showing off, overconfidence, group behaviour near water...

Question 5.4b **[2 marks]**

The Bawley Beach case shows that a young man dived from a jetty he had used safely before — but a sandbank had since formed beneath it. Explain why "I've done it here before" is a dangerous reason to skip checking water depth.

What causes depth to change? Why does prior experience create false confidence?

Question 5.4c **[2 marks]**

Unsafe diving causes 10% of all spinal cord injuries in Australia. Design ONE specific, realistic action you could take if you saw a friend about to dive into a river or dam at an unfamiliar location. What would you say or do — and why?

Think about: what words would actually work with your friend? What would you point out about the risk?

6 Personal Action Plan & Communication Campaign

Activity 6.1 — Personal Water Safety Action Plan

Individual | ~12 min

6.1a — My Swimming Goals

What is one swimming or water safety skill you want to improve this year?

6.1b — My SwimSafe Commitment

Write the FIVE LSV SwimSafe rules. Circle the one most important for you personally. Explain why below.

Rule 1: ___________ Rule 2: ___________ Rule 3: ___________

Most important for me because:

6.1c — My Safety Action Plan

Circle the scenario most relevant to you:

Beach day at Torquay / Mornington Peninsula | River or lake trip (e.g. Yarra, Eildon) | Pool party at a friend's house | Kayaking / paddling trip (paddle.org.au)

Plan Element	My Plan:
Hazards I might face	
Safety strategies I'll use	
Emergency plan (if something goes wrong)	
Equipment I'll bring	
Who I'll go with (buddy rule!)	

Activity 6.2 — Communication Campaign (Assessment Task)

Individual | ~25 min | Summative

Create a short water safety communication product for a specific audience. Choose ONE option:

All options must include:

At least ONE accurate statistic with its source URL | A clear safety message | A call to action

Option	Task Description
A — Social media post	Design 1-2 Instagram/TikTok slides for 13-17 year olds. Include a statistic, a visual element (drawn or described), and a call to action.
B — Letter to Year 5 student	Write a 200-word letter explaining THREE things they must know about Victorian water safety before summer.
C — Multilingual fact sheet (Extension)	Design a simple fact sheet explaining beach flags and Victorian waterway dangers for someone new to Australia. At least 5 key points and 2 statistics.

Plan your campaign:

Option chosen: ________________________________

Target audience: ______________________________

Statistic I will use: _________________________

Source URL: ___________________________________

Key message: __________________________________

Call to action: _______________________________

Draft your campaign here (or attach a separate page):

Self-Assessment

Rate your confidence in each area. Circle: **Not yet confident** / **Getting there** / **Confident**

Skill / Knowledge Area	Not yet confident	Getting there	Confident
Identifying beach flags and their meanings	**O**	**O**	**O**
Knowing what to do if caught in a rip current	**O**	**O**	**O**
Following DRS ABCD in an emergency	**O**	**O**	**O**
Recalling all 5 LSV SwimSafe rules	**O**	**O**	**O**
Making safe decisions near water	**O**	**O**	**O**
Understanding Victorian drowning statistics	**O**	**O**	**O**
Identifying hazards at different waterway types	**O**	**O**	**O**
Explaining the Throw, Don't Go rescue principle	**O**	**O**	**O**

One thing I want to learn more about:

Life Saving Victoria: lsv.com.au | Drowning Reports: lsv.com.au/research/victorian-drowning-reports/ | RLSSA: royallifesaving.com.au | BeachSafe: beachsafe.org.au | Paddle Australia: paddle.org.au | Parks Victoria: park.vic.gov.au | Victorian Curriculum: victoriancurriculum.vcaa.vic.edu.au